

THIS PAGE WILL CHANGE YOUR LIFE

Growth mindset – transform your mind forever

Are you wondering how to get on better at school? Have you ever felt that you're good at some things but not at others? Then perhaps it's time to start thinking differently about school, and even yourself. Carol Dweck, a Professor of Psychology from Stanford University, says people may not **be aware of** their own **'mindset'**, but mindsets have a huge influence on learning, **skills development**, personal relationships and **professional achievement**. Your mindset **determines** your **attitude** to your abilities. For example, you might consider yourself to be good (or bad) at sport or maths or languages. Or you might feel that you can be good at anything if you try hard enough.

What mindset do you have? To find out, consider these situations:

1 You read a short message in English, but it's hard to understand. What would you think?

a It's no use! I'm just not very good at languages.

b I haven't studied English for long, but one day I'll be able to read this.

2 You try to join a school sports team, but you fail to get in. What do you say to yourself?

a It's because I'm not good at sport.

b I'm not good enough yet, but if I train, I might get in next time.

These situations **illustrate** the difference between fixed and growth mindsets. People with a fixed **mindset** **tend to** answer a) to both questions. People with a growth mindset tend to answer b).

FIXED MINDSET PEOPLE ...

- think they are born with the ability to be good at some things and not at others.
- believe that success comes from talent rather than effort.
- don't feel that they can change what they're like as a person.
- dislike failure and focus on what they are 'good' at – they avoid difficult **challenges** and things they're not 'good' at.
- like doing well at tasks that will get a reward or please their school or parents, for example getting top marks in an exam.

GROWTH MINDSET PEOPLE ...

- think they are born with the ability to be good at anything if they try hard enough.
- believe that success comes from effort rather than talent.
- like adapting to new situations and **challenges**.
- don't mind failure and they learn from it – they'd never think 'I'm no good at this' or 'There's no use even trying.'
- do things for their own sake – for example, they might join a team because they find it personally rewarding, not because they want **praise**.

Did you know that when we learn something new, or when we have to **concentrate** to **figure out** an answer to a problem, our body creates new **nerve connections** within the brain? People with a growth **mindset** are always trying out new things and developing their skills and abilities, and so their brains are always growing.

Do you want to get the most out of your education? Do you want a **content** and **prosperous** life? There's no question that adopting a 'growth **mindset**' is the best decision you could ever make about your future. If you can't already **take the** growth mindset **approach** (and most people don't!), the question you should be asking yourself is not 'Should I change the way I see myself?' ... the big question is 'How quickly can I change?'

So, where do you begin? The good news is that changing your **mindset** doesn't happen all at once – it's a **gradual** process, and every small step counts. One of the best places to start is simply to pay attention to the way you talk to yourself. When something goes wrong, do you say 'I can't do this' or do you say 'I can't do this yet'? That one small word – *yet* – makes an **enormous** difference. It means you believe improvement is possible, and that belief is the foundation of a growth mindset.

Another key step is to change the way you think about effort. People with a fixed **mindset** often believe that if you have to work hard at something, it means you're not **naturally talented** at it. But the opposite is actually true. Working hard is exactly what builds talent. Every time you practise a skill – whether it's writing, playing an instrument, or solving maths problems – you are literally making your brain stronger. Scientists call this process **neuroplasticity**, and it shows us that the brain is not fixed. It changes throughout your entire life.

It's also important to learn how to **handle** criticism and **setbacks** in a healthy way. For people with a fixed **mindset**, negative feedback can feel like a personal attack – proof that they are simply not good enough. For people with a growth mindset, however, feedback is valuable information. It tells them what they need to work on next. In fact, some of the world's most successful people – scientists, athletes, writers, and entrepreneurs – say that their biggest failures taught them more than their greatest successes.

Finally, remember that adopting a growth **mindset** is not about pretending everything is easy or that you enjoy every challenge. It's about believing that **challenges** are **worthwhile** – that the effort you put in today will lead to results tomorrow. The next time you feel **frustrated** or stuck, try asking yourself: '*What can I learn from this?*' That question alone could be the start of your transformation.

ACTIVITIES

3

Read the article again and answer the questions. Write *Fixed* for people with a fixed mindset or *Growth* for people with a growth mindset.

- 1 Who thinks we're born with certain characteristics?
- 2 Who thinks achievement is a result of working hard?
- 3 Who thinks we can learn from our mistakes?
- 4 Who feels it's important to get high scores?
- 5 Whose brain keeps on growing?

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Match the highlighted words and phrases in the article to the meanings. Then write one sentence for each phrase.

- 1 do things in a certain way
- 2 know that something exists
- 3 getting better at doing things
- 4 doing well in your career
- 5 do things simply because you like doing them

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Read the new section of the article and answer the questions.

- 1 What is 'neuroplasticity' and why does it matter?
- 2 Why do people with a growth mindset find criticism useful?
- 3 What question does the article suggest you ask yourself when you feel stuck?
- 4 According to the article, what is a growth mindset NOT about?

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Think of a time when you faced a challenge. Write four sentences describing what happened using the ideas from the article.

Use these phrases to help you:

At first, I thought ... / I decided to ... / I found that ... / In the end, ...

■ TALKING POINTS

Are there any advantages to having a fixed mindset?

Do you think this page will change your life?

Think of someone you admire. Do they have a growth mindset? Give examples.

Is it ever too late to change your mindset? Why / Why not?